

The Best Places to Eat Cherry Kebabs

Zmorod expensive

There's a special ambience at this delightful restaurant, which sits in an elegant courtyard at the center of a beautifully restored 17th-century house. An ornate wrought-iron staircase climbs up a cool limestone wall, while overhead, intricate lanterns cast a lambent glow on the diners below. The atmosphere intensifies when the dining area is full of families and giggling couples, as fleet-footed waiters bring plate after plate of authentic Syrian delights to each table. The *kabab bil karaz* here is famous across Syria. The cherries and lamb are sourced locally, so both are wonderfully fresh. If you arrive early in the cherry season, the rich, spicy, dark sauce has a sourer edger to it, while later on it's sweeter, as the cherries ripen. Either way, the meat will be cooked to pink and tender perfection, and goes superbly with warm flatbread and fresh salad leaves. Like all Syrian spreads, a variety of dishes should be added, from a spicy *muhammara* red pepper paste with pomegranate molasses to a smoky *baba ghanoush* dip of mashed eggplant.

Raheb Bouhaira Street, Jdeideh, Aleppo; open noon–late daily; www.zmorod.com

Also in Aleppo

Club d'Alep (+963 21 211 3500; expensive) is quite possibly the best restaurant in the country, but unfortunately it's a private members club. In Syria, however, more than anywhere else on Earth, people are so friendly, warm, and welcoming that it shouldn't necessarily stop you from getting in. A friendly word with your hotel manager may be all that's needed. The reward is simply fantastic food, from the cherry kebabs to the desert truffles with lamb. **Bazar Al-Charq (www.bazaralcharq.com/aleppoe.htm; moderate)** is a cavernous restaurant in a stone cellar, offering all kinds of kebabs and even some rustic Bedouin dishes.

Also in Syria

Al Halabi (www.fourseasons.com/damascus; expensive) is one of the best restaurants in Damascus, but even this grand venue has a distinctly Aleppine bent. "Halab" is the ancient name for Aleppo, and Aleppine (Halabian) chef Mohammed Helal's food bears all the adventurous hallmarks of Aleppo's cuisine. Highlights are the cherry kebab and the *kebbeh saffarjaliyeh* (spiced lamb and bulgur wheat patties with quince, pomegranate, and rice).

Around the World

Elsewhere in the Middle East, Dubai has a number of good restaurants offering great, authentic Syrian food, including **Aroos Damascus (+971 221 9825; inexpensive)** and **Sarai (+971 438 0640; moderate)**.



Above The cherry kebabs in Aleppo have a unique flavor that comes from the small, sour cherries that grow just outside the city

Left Fresh, dried, whole, crushed, and powdered spices are sold in bins, bags, and pyramids in Aleppo's labyrinthine covered souk